

Moonsea Rising - 20231216

Fouling The Ritual

As the priest shouts at the participants to continue the ritual, they begin fleeing Lirael through the single door. She notes three other portals, similar to the one she came through, though they're not fleeing into them. They're yelling to the priest to allow the guards to handle it and calling for the Merovingians. Beitris, Lirael, and Lennox recognize the name of the elite Zhentarim guard, long gone from this world.

Lennox hacks into the fleeing cultists. Beitris tries to return through the portal, but strikes the wall behind it. Lirael grabs the priest in her jaws and shakes him, then chomps him down whole. Beitris steps through another portal, as Harken attempts some kind of distraction, and follows her, with the others following as well.

On the other side, they find themselves in a small cell. After banging on the door a couple of times, Lirael releases her form, and everyone is able to get their breath. Harken manages to quickly pick the lock, as footsteps sound in the hallway beyond it. The female says, "be mindful of Galina. She and I are not always amicable." The male replies lightly, asking why he shouldn't have had this info prior. He agrees to mind his tongue, addressing the woman as "Strikeleader." Harken and Beitris both recognize the title as one from the Selunite sect known as the Silver Swords. Beitris wonders aloud if it might be Jessica Talianos, wife of the first Emperor Edric. Harken steps out to introduce himself, all smiles.

The tall, dark-haired woman is wearing silver-trimmed armor, and looks quite weary and battle-worn. The man with her seems jaunty by comparison, and leans back with his arms crossed and a chuckle, asking Harken, "oh, where did you come from?" Jessica asks if they are "Brulicos," and Beitris identifies them as Lathandrites. The woman demands to know what Lathandrites are doing in the Temple of the Whip. She address the man as "Edric", much to the shock of the party.

Jessica and Edric lead them further into the temple. They pass multiple novitiates of Loviatar, dressed in burlap, shoeless, dirty, and covered in small wounds. They are escorted into a large chamber, where a young girl with white hair and pale skin seems to be in charge of the Loviatarians.

Jessica begins negotiating with Galina -- presumably a Shadowbanks -- about the recovery of the missing noble scions. Beitris is cagey about being interrogated under magical compulsion in front of Edric and Jessica. She recognizes Lirael's lineage, and wonders at their appearance with the Silver Sword. Lirael tells her it's a long story, but likely has little bearing on her business at hand. The Whip Maiden is amenable, and has them escorted to more guest-oriented chambers.

Just the Facts

The party takes a few minutes to discuss the implications of being in the past, and possible interrogation by the high priestess. Beitris is worried about altering the past, though Harken and Lirael

point out that they may have already altered the past in the past, and to not alter it would be dangerous. Lirael ponders the priestess' recognition of her. Her grandmother spoke of Edric's liberation of Hillsfar, but not often of what the family was up to during the horrors.

They are eventually escorted back into the High Priestess' presence, and she casts a zone of truth on all of them. She seems initially convinced they are Zhentarim, but they assure her, under the zone, that they are not.

Lennox, Taevyn, and Harken immediately start spilling their guts, discussing the future, and their travel from it. Galina seems very interested in the future of her church and her house, and begins doing calculations on how this information might be useful to her. Under Galina's urging, Beitris lays out the history of the War of the Scions. She also asks Lirael about the Liberation of Hillsfar and Battle of Zhentil Keep. Lirael asks her how she knows her family, and Galina tells her they are powerful, but likely still enslaved under Malthir in Hillsfar.

Galina seems convinced that defeating Brule is in her house and church's best interest. She offers the party their lives, if they will be bound to help Edric defeat the orcish invasion. The shackled pair is brought back in and freed. Exiting a secret tunnel, they find themselves in the docks of a much smaller Melvaunt than Harken and Beitris remember. There is smoke and clamor in the distance, and it's clear that there's unrest in the city. Edric rushes them to a rowboat and they cast off and return to his ship ahead of any blockade.

Edric scampers up the rigging to the deck, with Taevyn following awkwardly behind. Jessica and Beitris are hauled aboard in baskets, weighted down as they are with armor. Edric has them made comfortable aboard the Vile Flame, and tells them they'll meet with Laronen in the morning. Torbick escorts them belowdecks, where they are brought to a section of bunks they can use for the duration.